



OFF-SIDE

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CHANGE YOUR MINDSET

Celebrating para-athletes as multidimensional individuals, beyond clichéd struggles, **could foster** genuine connections and progress.

In 2024, India's sporting fortunes were more of a dim flicker, with a few stray fireworks thrown in. While the year was headlined by the high of the ICC T20 World Cup in the USA and the Caribbean, the form and reputation of our cricketers and the national team took a beating as the year rolled on. The Olympic Games also saw the gulf grow further between promise and performance. The hope of a double-digit medal tally ended with six dreaded fourth-place finishes. And after a near miss here and a could-have-been there, suddenly even Tokyo's modest seven medals were a distant dream. India finished 71st with six medals.

The Paralympians were the real heroes in shining armour as they captured a record haul of 29 medals with seven golds at the Paris Games. Their acceptability and the acknowledgement of their star power saw brands collaborating with para-athletes, finally starting to look away from the cricket-cinema nexus. Before the start of the Paris 2024 Paralympics, brands like Mia by Tanishq, Thums Up, Hyundai, IndianOil, Adidas, and Puma actively supported the para movement and para-athletes.

"We supported 11 para-athletes who represented India at the Paralympic Games 2024. Athletes are role models, and it is our responsibility as the leading sports brand in India to strongly back them in their pursuit of excellence — regardless of age, gender, background or circumstance," Karthik Balagopalan, Managing Director of Puma India, said. Puma also signed P.V. Sindhu as its brand ambassador, signalling a gentle pivot away from its earlier cricket-only fixation.

"While cricket's dominance is unlikely to wane significantly, recurring failures at critical moments can open doors for other sports to gain traction. If organisations and stakeholders strategically promote Olympic and para sports during this period, they could carve out a more significant share of sponsorships and audience engagement," says Vinit Karnik, Managing Director, GroupM.

According to Sarvesh Kedia, co-founder and COO of Sportswise India, "The market is improving for para-athletes since the Paris Games. There has been good interest in corporate engagements for double para gold medallist Avani Lekhara."

The GroupM ESP Sporting Nation Report 2024 indicates that the Indian sports industry saw an upward surge of 11 per cent and is now worth Rs 15,766 crore, witnessing a four-fold growth in 10 years. Cricket, however, continues to monopolise more than 80 per cent of this market.

"Athletes who can connect with people on social media and inspire them with their journey are particularly valuable. Companies want to work with athletes who show promise for the future and perform well consistently," says Neerav Tomar, founder and managing director, IOS Sports. "Top stars like Lovlina Borgohain and Sindhu get brand deals throughout the four-year Olympic cycle, but most other athletes only attract brand interest during the Olympics or other major competitions."

Unless you are a Sindhu, a Neeraj Chopra, or a celebrated cricketer, long-term commitment from brands is still wishful thinking for most Indian athletes. While social media is full of heartfelt posts and triumphant hashtags, most brands are still stuck in the old-school mindset that their ambassadors must look and sound a certain way.

Athletes and para-athletes are regular people with regular lives, but blessed with exceptional talent. Brands and the media, perhaps, should stop fixating on just their struggles. We can't seem to decide whether to celebrate the victories of para-athletes or package them as inspirational struggles.

What if we just let them be ordinary? Show them as vibrant, multidimensional humans who love what they do and are brilliant at it. There's nothing more relatable than passion and excellence. And it's bound to connect more genuinely than the same tired, old clichés.